

Where the Past Still Breathes; Spring Break Book Recommendations for Young People

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Article Text

What does it mean to walk the exact same streets once lined with freedom seekers, entrepreneurs, writers and dreamers - young Black people who dared to imagine more?

For young people, history should feel *alive*. It should feel *personal*. It should say: **you belong here. You always have.**

That's why we're spotlighting the incredible books below that open a window into daily Black life in the 1800s Philadelphia.

These books are a great way to make the Philadelphia Black Metropolis *real* - which is so important to keeping history living and breathing for the next generation.

There's something here for all ages.

Elementary and Middle School

American Girl Addy

For elementary and middle school there's Addy from author Connie Porter in the American Girls Collection. Addy and her family have escaped plantation life via the Underground Railroad and have safely moved to Philadelphia during the mid 1800s, where they are thriving.

As young people engage with this book, they may want to walk the paths that Addy walked in. Many of the places in the books, like Trinity AME church, are based on real places, like Mother Bethel AME, which still stands. We've located where schools and churches were and put them on our map and into our guided walking tours page to help see and feel what Addy lived.

High School - Fiction

All We Were Promised

A great new book called *All We Were Promised* by Ashton Lattimore is perfect for high schoolers and young adults. This book follows Charlotte and Nell, two young Black women in 1838 Philadelphia, as they work to help Evie, a Freedom Seeker, escape from plantation life. This is an exciting read with a well-researched, fact based, fictional account of everything from romance to the burning of Pennsylvania Hall. Listen to this engaging excerpt from the book. This would be a great book to listen to on road trips during spring break.

The Garies and Their Friends

This book was written by Frank Webb in 1859. Frank Webb grew up in the Philadelphia Black Metropolis, so this book is really first hand knowledge. The story is full of life - birth, marriage, homes, churches, schools and all political and social change - through the experiences of a young Black boy, 12 year old Charlie. This book also has some violent content in the mob attack scenes, so parents and guardians may want to give it a read first.

This one is freely available in multiple formats.

High School - Non-Fiction

Notes from a Colored Girl

Finally, for those who want to move into primary sources, *Notes from a Colored Girl*, Karsonya White Whitehead's phenomenal research into Emilie Davis' diaries, are another great way to feel what day-to-day life was like in the Philadelphia Black Metropolis. Emilie wrote these diaries when she was a student at the Institute for Colored Youth during the Civil War.

If you're in Philadelphia, follow this read up with a visit to see the *actual diaries* at the Historical Society of Pennsylvania.

And check out this beautiful digital project by Dr. Judith Giesberg and the team at Villanova.

Here's author Karsonya Wise Whitehead describing daily life for Emilie Davis in Philadelphia during the 1860s.

It's Up to Us

These authors have done their part to bring history to life so that we can know, and feel, and imagine the extraordinary

ordinary existence of Black people in the 1800s. Now it's up to us to ensure we lift up these works to carry on our heritage far into the future.

Images

- Addy Walker from American Girls Collection —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_c9a0d33840484d9cab3e6b721e89392b~mv2.jpg
- Characters based in Philadelphia from Addy book collection —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_295010aa3c2849bf94356b05015809b6~mv2.jpg
- AI image of fictional character Charlie Ellis from The Garies and Their Friends —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_4e458ee61fbb4bdc93e14dc8f525ee8d~mv2.png

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